

Instructor: Date:

Learner: Regional Branch:

Program: Center:

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Let's Start!

Getting Familiar with User Manuals



Learning Outcome:

Designs a user manual that fulfills both the IT solution needs and the client requirements.

Understand how to write a good user manual.

Ask your partner:

- Have you read a user manual? What advantages and disadvantages have you found?
- Why is it so common that users do not read manuals?

Can Do Statements:

- I can explain how to create a good user manual.
- I can list the general guidelines to write a user manual.
- I can describe how to create a good first impression and how to enhance findability.





Let's Explore!

Listen to a phone conversation between Beth and Tim about how to create a manual.



Instructions: Read the text below.

- Beth:** Hi, Tim! I hope you're okay. I was wondering if you could give me a hand with some tips.
- Tim:** Hi, Beth. Sure! What do you want to know?
- Beth:** Well, I need to know how a user manual is done.
- Tim:** There are certain elements you need to consider before you start. If you want to make an interesting manual, first, you need to define the type of users selecting the right vocabulary and conceiving the final version of the product. If you don't want to make your users bored, you will need to write in clear terms what you want them to understand. And of course; if you present a problem about the product, you will make your users feel satisfied by providing solutions or recommendations about it.
- Beth:** What are the other general guidelines or components?
- Tim:** You should include a cover if the manual has more than 4 pages. You need to write a quick start guide, so users will know how to use the product easily and step by step. Do not forget the table of contents, and write clearly the instructions and functions in the body of the manual. Include clear pictures and diagrams if necessary.
- Beth:** I feel most customers do not get to read the manuals.
- Tim:** Right. Most customers go straight to use the product. That's the reason why creators need to make a good first impression within the first pages of the manual, highlighting the qualities, using appropriate and clear fonts, including pictures, selecting the correct size of the manual. It is also important to select the words carefully, using synonyms and providing short explanations only if needed.
- Beth:** That's pretty clear, I'll start working right away.



Let's Practice!

Beth is reviewing concepts before starting her manual.

Instructions: Draw a line to match the sentences from Column A with Column B.

COLUMN A

1. Instructions
2. Quick start guide
3. User manual
4. Guideline
5. Cover-

COLUMN B

- a. Simple introductory text that presents the basic operations of a product.
- b. A set of general instructions to determine a course of actions.
- c. The first page of a book or manual that protects it.
- d. To show the way something should be read or done.
- e. A document to give full assistance in the use and operation of a product.



Let's Practice!

Beth and Tim are completing the manual creating "checklist"*

* "Checklist" is a list of items to take into account when doing something.

Instructions: Read the sentences. Write the missing words. Use: divided / are / is / used and organized.

1. The manual is _____ in sections for better understanding.
2. Synonyms _____ included on the manual.
3. Information is _____ hierarchically for easy access.
4. A glossary _____ included using technical terms.
5. Images are _____ to illustrate manual's instructions.





Extension Activity

Checking a manual

Instructions: Complete the following steps. Fill in the Self-Assessment.

- Look for a manual.
- Read the manual and see if it has all the characteristics of a good manual.
- Write about all the corrections you would do to make it better.
- Show your ideas to a partner or your instructor.

Self-Assessment

Yes

No

- I read a manual
- I check it has all the required characteristics.
- I write about the changes I would make
- I present my ideas to a partner.

☐	☐
☐	☐
☐	☐
☐	☐



Target Words

- guideline** (noun): a set of general instructions or indications about something.
e.g. What are the other general guidelines or components?
- highlight** (verb): to emphasize or focus the attention on something.
e.g. creators need to make a good first impression within the first pages of the manual, highlighting the qualities, using appropriate and clear fonts.
- wonder** (verb): to ask oneself a question.
e.g. I was wondering if you could give me a hand with some tips.
- conceive** (verb): to think or make an idea of something.
e.g. You need to define the type of users selecting the right vocabulary and conceiving the final version of the product.
- cover** (noun): the shelter or first page of a book.
e.g. You should include a cover if the manual has more than 4 pages.
- give a hand** (expression): to help or assist.
e.g. I was wondering if you could give me a hand with some tips.



Learning Points

Adjectives ending in **-ed** and **-ing**.

Adjectives help us describe the characteristics of subjects.

Adjectives are words that describe the subject and their characteristics. In English, you can create adjectives by adding finishing **-ing** or **-ed** to some words and verbs. Although they may look similar they have different meanings.

-ed Adjectives:

This type of adjectives describes emotions and how people feel about something.

Example:

*He was very **bored** in the class.*

*I'm **confused** about the new software.*

-ing Adjectives:

This type of adjectives describes the thing that generates the emotion.

Example:

*The class was very **boring**.*

*The new software is **confusing**.*

Look at some examples of adjectives in the table below.

Adjectives	
-ing	-ed
Confusing	Confused
Amazing	Amazed
Exciting	Excited
Disgusting	Disgusted
Annoying	Annoyed
Disgusting	Disgusted
Tiring	Tired
Disappointing	Disappointed

Examples

- *If you want to make an interesting manual, first you need to define the type of users.*
- *you will make your users feel satisfied by providing solutions or recommendations about it.*



Learning Points

How to create a good first impression and how to enhance findability.

When you write a manual, you need to make sure you do it well to catch users' attention.

Generally, most users do not get to the point where they read the manual; and if they do so, writers want to assure manuals are catchy and make a good first impression when seen. These are some tips you should take into account when creating a manual:

- Use a clear font
- Use effective and clear pictures
- Avoid big amounts of texts
- Include customer service line number
- Use color
- Make sure the size fits the product

How to enhance findability?

Sometimes, users get frustrated because they do not find what they want in the manual, it happens generally because the words they look for and the ones in the manual are not the same. Take into account the following tips to increase findability:

- Divide into sections
- Organize information hierarchically
- Make sure you include synonyms
- Include a glossary with technical terms